# Swedenborg and the New Church

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There are Societies of the New Jerusalem, or more simply, of the New Church, located in many parts of the world. Two are in Sydney. When I talk of a Society of the New Church, I am referring to a group of people who, as individuals, have received and acknowledged the Doctrines given to the world in the theological Writings of Emanuel Swedenborg and who meet together both to worship the Lord and to learn more of Him according to the way those doctrines reveal Him to us. As we shall see later on, and I mention it at this point because it needs to be stressed, the New Church is in every way a Christian Church, for those who are members of it look to the Lord Jesus Christ as the God of heaven and earth and know it is their duty and responsibility to strive to live according to His Divine Teaching.

Because questions are frequently asked about it, I propose to examine the relationship which exists, or existed, between Emanuel Swedenborg and the New Church, the distinguishing feature of which is the acceptance of the teaching and doctrines given through him. People understandably ask whether Swedenborg founded the New Church? Well did he? And how is Swedenborg regarded by those who are of the New Church? Sometimes the New Church is called the Swedenborgian Church. Since this title suggests followers of Swedenborg, disciples of him so to speak, is it appropriate?

Let me remind you, that Swedenborg lived between the years 1688 and 1772. As a younger man, he gained a European reputation both as a scientist and as a philosopher. However in 1745, at the age of 57, he abandoned his career and turned to theology. Try as he had done for years beforehand to establish such things as the existence of the soul and to provide a basis for religious belief from scientific and philosophical reasoning, it came to him in that year that these are things that must be revealed from above. Four years later, and written under divine inspiration as they were, he began publishing his theological Writings; Writings which lie at the heart of a new Christian age and are its inspiration, and in which there is given a whole new world of understanding concerning the Lord, concerning the Word, concerning Divine Providence, concerning the purpose of life and concerning the reality of the spiritual world.

Throughout this entire period Swedenborg never sought to proselytize, or form a Church, or even to gather readers of those theological Writings around him. Indeed it was not until four years before his death that he even allowed his name to go forward as their author. For the previous seventeen years, that is from 1749 to 1768, the books had been published anonymously, though in time it became known that Swedenborg had written them and he distributed them, once published, to leading members of Parliament and to prominent Churchmen of those times. He also answered questions about them when he was asked, and defended them when they were under attack. But this was all.

In many places in those Writings the establishment of a New Church is spoken of, but it is important to remember that what is meant, essentially, is a new and much more meaningful relationship with the Lord into which henceforth people would be able to enter. Everything Swedenborg wrote is directed toward this end. In the final analysis here is their fundamental purpose. Treat of different subjects though the different books he wrote do, yet their purpose is to lead people into this new relationship with the Lord. This also, is what mattered to Swedenborg. And this is what his mission was all about.

Whilst there were affirmative receivers of the doctrines given in Swedenborg's Writings in his lifetime, there was no attempt made to establish any kind of organisation in connection with them. And it was not until eleven years after his death, in 1783, that a handful of people met in London for the purposes of reading the Doctrines and conversation about them. The organised New Church, now located in many parts of the world, and two societies of which exist here in Sydney, has its origin with these London meetings. From England, the New Church spread to Europe and America. It was brought to Australia in 1838 by one of the members of the Pitman family, of short-hand fame.

We can begin now to answer some of the questions which, as we noted, people ask concerning Swedenborg and the New Church. One of these was whether Swedenborg founded another Church. And the answer is no, he didn't, though like we've seen, receivers of the doctrines contained in his theological Writings did. Above all

else Swedenborg saw himself simply as a servant of the Lord; an instrument through whom there could be revealed from heaven the doctrines of the New Jerusalem; the many things which the Lord, while on earth, had not been able to tell His followers (see John 16:12).

And this is how those in the New Church look upon him today. He is regarded as an instrument through whom a new revelation could be given. And it is this Revelation which is of paramount interest and concern in the Church.

Frequently questions are asked concerning the principal teachings of the New Church and how it differs from the teaching of other Churches. What is it in the Writings of Swedenborg which so sets them apart? We talk of the Doctrines of the New Church. What is new and different about them? And by way of a response all I can attempt to do here is summarise the principal points involved.

Concerning God first of all: It has been the traditional teaching of the Churches that there are three separate, though co-equal Persons in the Godhead, Father, Son and Holy Spirit, and that at the time of the Incarnation, for instance, God the Father sent His Son into the world to suffer vicariously of man's behalf. In the New Church it is believed otherwise; that God is one and indivisible; that He Himself came into the world by assuming human nature which He glorified and fully united to Himself; and that the trinity is not a trinity of Persons but of essentials within this one God who so manifested Himself on earth and came among us as Jesus Christ.

And then there is the teaching of the New Church, concerning the internal sense of the Word. Now, there are some parts of the Word which obviously contain within them an internal meaning, as when the Lord said "I am the Bread of Life" (John 6) or "I am the vine" (John 15), or in the case of the many parables He spoke, the most famous of which, probably, is the parable of the Sower, and whose deeper implications are plain for all to see. However it has now been shown that the whole of the Divine Word likewise contains an internal, spiritual, meaning. Fable-like, for example, as the stories in Genesis of Creation, of the Garden of Eden, and of Noah's Ark and the Flood may seem, yet they have been used by the Lord as vehicles for teaching people concerning the possibilities which lie before them in regeneration and, so far as the story of the Flood is concerned, about how the Lord is able to protect and rescue people in times of temptation, when evils and falsities threaten to overwhelm and swamp them.

What impresses and interests a great many people in turning to the Writings of Swedenborg is all that is written there concerning the continuity of life after death. The New Church teaches that men and women are spiritual beings who are first born into this world in order that in the midst of the different experiences, challenges and opportunities that come to them here, they might choose either to live for others or to live for themself. Depending on how they decide, they will afterwards make their home in heaven or in hell. The spiritual world is not far away. Perhaps the best way of thinking of it is as another dimension of consciousness.

And then there is the teaching concerning marriage and concerning the male and female minds, different, though complimentary, which make eternally enduring and ever-fulfilling marriage possible. One whole book of the Writings of Swedenborg is devoted to the subject. Much is said also concerning the Divine Providence; teaching which at last makes it understandable how a God of Love has to permit suffering and disorders because of the greater issues involved.